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Cyrus

The Persian king whom God called "my shepherd," who sent the exiles home to rebuild the temple.

Cyrus founded the Persian Empire. In 539 BC his forces took Babylon, and within a year he decreed that any Jew who wished could go home and rebuild the house of the Lord. He even sent back the vessels Nebuchadnezzar had taken. Cyrus was not an Israelite and did not follow Israel's God alone. Yet Isaiah names him God's "shepherd" and "anointed," called "though thou hast not known me." Cyrus shows that God can move the heart of any ruler to carry out his promises.

At a glance

Name	Persian <i>Kurush</i> ; Hebrew <i>Koresh</i> ; "Cyrus the Great"
Family	Son of Cambyses of Anshan (from records outside the Bible)
Reign	King of Persia c. 559–530 BC; of Babylon from 539 BC
Titles	"My shepherd" (Isa 44:28); "his anointed" (Isa 45:1)
Famous act	Decree of 538 BC to rebuild the temple (Ezra 1:1–4)
Key people	Daniel, Sheshbazzar, Zerubbabel, Jeshua the priest
Main passages	Isaiah 44:28–45:13; Ezra 1; 6:3–5; 2 Chr 36:22–23
New Testament	Not named

"That saith of Cyrus, He is my shepherd, and shall perform all my pleasure: even saying to Jerusalem, Thou shalt be built; and to the temple, Thy foundation shall be laid."

Isaiah 44:28, KJV

The life of Cyrus

Dates approximate (BC). Traditionally Isaiah son of Amoz named Cyrus about 150 years ahead; many scholars date Isaiah 40–55 to a later prophet in the exile, in the 540s BC.

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| Before his reign | <div>● Called by name
Through the prophet, God names Cyrus as his shepherd and anointed, who will subdue nations and order Jerusalem and the temple rebuilt. <i>Isaiah 44:28–45:7</i></div> |
| c. 559 BC
<i>Becomes king</i> | <div>● Rise of Persia
Cyrus becomes king of Anshan. Within twenty years he conquers the Medes, Lydia and much of the east, "to subdue nations before him." <i>Isaiah 45:1–3</i></div> |
| c. 539 BC
<i>Babylon falls</i> | <div>● The Medes and Persians take Babylon
On the night of Belshazzar's feast, Babylon falls to the Medes and Persians, as the writing on the wall foretold. Daniel continues to serve in the new government and prospers "in the reign of Cyrus the Persian." <i>Daniel 5:28–31; 6:28</i></div> |
| c. 538 BC
<i>1st year over Babylon</i> | <div>● The decree
God stirs his spirit, and Cyrus proclaims in writing across his kingdom that the Jews may return and build the house of God. He orders the costs paid from the royal treasury. <i>Ezra 1:1–4; 6:3–5; 2 Chronicles 36:22–23</i></div> |
| c. 538/537 BC
<i>The journey home</i> | <div>● The vessels return
Cyrus has his treasurer, Mithredath, count out 5,400 gold and silver vessels from Babylon's temple. They are handed to Sheshbazzar, prince of Judah, who carries them home with the returning exiles. <i>Ezra 1:7–11; 5:14–15</i></div> |
| c. 536 BC
<i>3rd year</i> | <div>● Daniel's last vision
Daniel's final vision, beside the Tigris River, is dated by Cyrus's reign. Meanwhile, enemies in Judah hire counsellors to slow the temple work throughout his reign. Cyrus dies c. 530 BC. <i>Daniel 10:1, 4; Ezra 4:4–5</i></div> |

Key activities

Did Cyrus believe in Israel's God? In Ezra 1:2 he says "the LORD God of heaven" gave him his kingdoms. On the Cyrus Cylinder he gives Marduk the credit. Many think he honoured each people's god in its own terms. Isaiah says God used him "though thou hast not known me."

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- 1 Was called before he knew God.** God named him, held his right hand, and "girded" him for his work. *Isaiah 45:1-5*
 - 2 Conquered Babylon.** His rise ended the empire that had destroyed Jerusalem, as Daniel had told Belshazzar. *Daniel 5:28-31*
 - 3 Proclaimed the return.** He invited any of God's people to "go up to Jerusalem" and build the house of the Lord God of Israel. *Ezra 1:1-4*
 - 4 Sent back the temple vessels.** He returned the gold and silver vessels Nebuchadnezzar had taken. *Ezra 1:7-11*
 - 5 Paid for the rebuilding.** His decree set the temple's size and ordered the expenses paid from the king's house. He also allowed cedar to be brought from Lebanon. *Ezra 3:7; 6:3-5*
 - 6 Kept Daniel in service.** Daniel continued "unto the first year of king Cyrus" and prospered in his reign. *Daniel 1:21; 6:28*
 - 7 Left a lasting decree.** Years later, when the temple work was challenged, the record of his decree was found and protected the builders. *Ezra 5:13-17; 6:1-5*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Cyrus.

Old Testament

Isaiah 44:28–45:13	Named God's shepherd and anointed to rebuild Jerusalem
2 Chronicles 36:22–23; Ezra 1:1–4	His decree fulfils Jeremiah's word; the Hebrew Bible's traditional last words
Ezra 3:7; 4:3, 5; 5:13–17; 6:3–5, 14	His decree is the builders' legal ground
Daniel 1:21; 6:28; 10:1	Daniel serves into his reign
Echo: Proverbs 21:1; Jeremiah 29:10	The king's heart in God's hand; seventy years

New Testament

Echo: John 19:11; Romans 13:1	Earthly power given "from above"
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For discussion

1. *Observe:* What does God say he will do for Cyrus in Isaiah 45:1–4, and why?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think God chose a foreign king, rather than an Israelite, to send his people home?
3. *Apply:* Is there a leader or authority in your life you find hard to trust? How might God be at work even there?
4. *Apply:* Cyrus's decree opened a door, but each family still had to choose to go. What open door is God setting before you right now?